

Bishpan: The Dust Penance — Story Bible

a web series of 8 episodes, 20 minutes each

The critics' verdict

PASSED — every critic scored 8 or more (version 3).

Critic	Score	Verdict
Story doctor	8/10	This is a remarkably strong, visceral folk-horror concept. The brilliant climax, where the rational doctor weaponizes modern medicine to intentionally trigger his own supernatural possession, is top-tier storytelling. However, a few execution flaws give away the central mystery too early and strain logical plotting.
Audience critic	8/10	This is a highly compelling, fresh take on possession horror. Combining clinical medical precision with ancient Odia rituals creates a uniquely terrifying atmosphere, and the climax—weaponizing a sedative to willingly surrender to the Goddess—is brilliant. Fixing the artificial stall with the CCTV footage and clarifying the physical evidence from 15 years ago will make it an exceptional thriller.
Odisha culture expert	8/10	This is a remarkably strong and atmospheric story bible that deeply respects Odisha's rural traditions. The writer's integration of the Danda Nata penances into the murder mystery is genuinely brilliant and culturally accurate. With a few minor corrections to local police and bureaucratic procedures, this is ready to be a standout Odia thriller.

Rounds: v1 (6/8/9) → v2 (6/6/8) → v3 (8/8/8)

Problems still open:

- **[major] Story doctor — Episode 1, Ending hook:** Soumya wakes up with a blister that mirrors the victim's internal burn, and his fingers smell of Jhuna resin. This is a massive giveaway. The user's prompt specifically mandates that the audience must not know Soumya is the killer until the twist. Any viewer watching a psychological horror will immediately connect his matching wound to him committing the murder in his sleep, ruining the Episode 6 reveal. *Fix:* Remove the matching blister and the smell of Jhuna resin. Have Soumya wake up simply feeling inexplicably exhausted with intense muscle aches (which he dismisses as sleeping on a terrible clinic cot) and maybe finding local red dust on his shoes, which he assumes is just from walking around the village.
- **[major] Story doctor — Episode 7, Clue (earned):** Soumya uses the chisel to 'pry deeper into the temple stones' and finds contractor Deba's 2009 ledger. This makes no logical sense. First, the Pujari died the day after the theft; why would he have Deba's financial ledger to hide? Second, Soumya already opened this exact hiding spot in Episode 4 to find the jewelry box. Prying 'deeper' into the same hole three episodes later feels highly contrived. *Fix:* Change the location of the ledger. When Soumya is hunted by the mob, he breaks into Deba's abandoned, sealed construction office in the temple courtyard using the heavy chisel to smash the door lock or a small lockbox, discovering the ledger that proves Balaram paid Deba on the exact night of the theft.
- **[major] Story doctor — Episode 6, Cold open:** IIC Meera examines the corpse of the drowned police chief and finds the surgical incisions behind his ears. However, the police chief was murdered back in Episode 4. A two-episode delay for a police inspector to examine the murdered body of a former police chief breaks procedural plausibility. *Fix:* Have the local village doctor (in Balaram's pocket) quickly rule it an accidental drowning in

Episode 4. In Episode 6, Meera receives the delayed official forensic autopsy report she secretly ordered from the district hospital, which flags the microscopic, expert surgical cuts that the local doctor missed.

- **[major] Audience critic — Episodes 3 to 6:** The broken laptop charger is a very weak, frustrating stall. A modern doctor in 2024 wouldn't wait three days to check crucial security footage of an intruder; he would simply go to a local mobile shop to buy a card reader or adapter. It makes the protagonist look passive and unintelligent. *Fix:* Soumya checks the footage immediately in Episode 3, but the cheap camera's infrared is blown out or the killer is silhouetted. He doesn't know it is him. In Episode 6, Kavita uses her high-end lab laptop to enhance the video contrast, revealing a distinct scar, his specific wristwatch, or the undeniable clinical grip he uses to hold the scalpel.
- **[major] Audience critic — Episode 7:** The 2009 ledger hidden beneath the idol makes no logical sense. Balaram and Deba would not bring a physical accounting ledger into a dark temple while committing a diamond heist, nor could a dying Pujari easily hide a book while being beaten to death by a mob. *Fix:* Change the physical proof to something visceral that was snatched during the struggle. The Pujari tore off Balaram's custom, engraved gold political ring or a distinctive piece of his jewelry, shoving it under the floor stone along with the empty box before dying. Balaram has been searching for it for 15 years.
- **[major] Odisha culture expert — Episode 1: Villain's move and Side story:** Deba dies a grotesque public death. If Balaram forces a cremation right in front of IIC Meera without a post-mortem, Meera looks either entirely corrupt or utterly incompetent, contradicting her 'tough skeptic' character. An IIC would mandate an Unnatural Death (UD) case for a public sudden death. *Fix:* Have Balaram's men rush the body away in the immediate chaotic aftermath before Meera arrives from the police station. By the time Meera reaches the village, the pyre is already lit, and Balaram claims it was a natural heart attack, giving her solid grounds for suspicion without breaking police protocol.

1. The promise

Logline: When a mysterious madness strikes the village that exiled his family, a pragmatic doctor returns to cure the afflicted, only to discover the disease is a bloody retribution acting through his own hands.

The question that keeps people watching: Is the village suffering from a toxic epidemic, or is the Goddess actually exacting a long-delayed blood debt through an invisible assassin?

What the audience is paying for: Folk-horror and psychological dread set against the intense, visceral backdrop of Odisha's rural penance rituals.

Why "wow": The horrific realization that the hero's supposed medical condition of extreme exhaustion is actually the Goddess commandeering his body for brutal, ritualistic justice.

2. The hidden truth

Fifteen years ago, ambitious local politician Balaram Rout orchestrated the theft of the Kali idol's priceless diamond eyes to fund his first election campaign. He used local contractor Deba to physically steal them. When the temple Pujari discovered the theft and hid the empty box, Balaram and Deba framed him, whipping the village into a frenzy. The mob brutally murdered the Pujari. His mother, Sulochana, fled to Bhubaneswar with her young grandson, Soumya. Today, following Sulochana's death, the trauma has awakened within Soumya, allowing the Goddess Kali to possess his unconscious, sleeping body to enact ritualistic vengeance using his medical skills without his waking mind knowing.

- **April 2009:** Balaram Rout and Deba steal the Kali idol's eyes from the Rambhadipur temple.
- **April 2009 (Next Day):** The Pujari interrupts the theft's aftermath, hides the empty box, and is beaten to death by a mob incited by Balaram.
- **April 2009 (Night):** Sulochana escapes Rambhadipur with young Soumya, relocating to Bhubaneswar and changing their last name.
- **2010 to 2023:** Balaram becomes a powerful MLA. Soumya grows up to become a successful doctor, suppressing his childhood trauma.
- **March 2024:** Sulochana passes away, leaving behind cassette tapes of her stories. The grief triggers Soumya's suppressed trauma, making his body a vessel for Kali Mata while he sleeps.
- **April 2024 (Start of Series):** Soumya returns to Rambhadipur to run a free health camp, unaware that at night his body is hunting down his father's killers.

Who knows what at the start:

- **Dr. Soumya Dash:** Thinks his father died in a random communal riot. He believes he is just suffering from severe exhaustion and heavy sleep, completely unaware of his violent night-terrors.
- **Balaram Rout:** Knows he orchestrated the theft and murder, and hides the stolen diamond eyes in a secret vault.
- **Deba:** Knows he physically stole the eyes and struck the first blow against the Pujari.
- **IIC Meera:** Knows the contractor's death was not natural, hiding her suspicion that the old temple faction is involved.

3. Characters

Dr. Soumya Dash (28) — Protagonist

Hero / Unwitting Assassin. Clean-cut city doctor, wears scrubs or neat casuals, always looks slightly exhausted with dark circles.

- **Wants:** To scientifically cure the strange epidemic in his ancestral village and honor his late grandmother's memory.
- **Needs:** To uncover the horrific truth of his father's death and accept his dark blood-legacy.
- **Secret:** He is suppressing severe childhood trauma that manifests as intense, deep sleep and exhaustion.
- **Lie they believe:** Believes science and medicine can explain every human affliction and that the past is firmly dead.
- **Changes the plot when:** He secretly installs a CCTV camera in his clinic to catch a suspected intruder, ultimately capturing footage of his own unconscious body leaving to kill.
- **Arc:** From a pragmatic, rational man of science to a fugitive avatar of divine retribution who sacrifices his normal life for justice.

Balaram Rout (55) — No relation - the man who framed the hero's father

Villain. Wears crisp white kurtas, heavy gold rings, always accompanied by armed guards.

- **Wants:** To win the upcoming election and bulldoze the old Kali temple to build a lucrative tourist resort.
- **Needs:** To be held accountable for the blood on his hands.

- **Secret:** He possesses the original diamond eyes of the Goddess, hiding them in plain sight as collateral for political funding.
- **Lie they believe:** Believes power and money make him immune to consequences and that religion is just a tool to control the masses.
- **Changes the plot when:** He frames Soumya for the new murders, inciting a village mob to execute him exactly as he did to the Pujari 15 years ago.
- **Arc:** From an untouchable, arrogant ruler of the region to a terrified, broken man executed publicly during the final ritual.

Kavita (27) — His fiancée and medical colleague

Ally and Anchor. Modern, practical, wears elegant sarees or doctor's coats, carries high-end mobile lab gear.

- **Wants:** To help Soumya cure the village epidemic and then bring him back to Bhubaneswar to marry him.
- **Needs:** To realize that medical ethics cannot govern divine retribution, and she must let Soumya face his destiny.
- **Secret:** She secretly brought a pre-filled syringe (PFS) of Midazolam, initially planning to institutionalize Soumya if his mental health cracked.
- **Lie they believe:** Believes love and modern therapy can fix any deep-rooted trauma.
- **Changes the plot when:** She discovers the horrific CCTV footage alongside Soumya, deciding to leave the Midazolam syringe with him out of agonizing love rather than turning him in.
- **Arc:** From a confident, rational medical professional to a horrified witness who must abandon her ethics to let the man she loves go.

IIC Meera (30) — No relation - the investigating police officer

Skeptic / Detective. Tough, practical police uniform, carries a notebook and a heavy flashlight.

- **Wants:** To logically solve the bizarre murders and earn a transfer out of the rural Rambhadipur Police Station.
- **Needs:** To accept that some forces in Rambhadipur defy the Indian Penal Code.
- **Secret:** She was demoted to this rural jurisdiction for speaking out against a corrupt politician and hates politicians.
- **Lie they believe:** Believes every crime has a clear, mundane motive and a rational human perpetrator.
- **Changes the plot when:** She deduces Soumya's true identity by observing him perform a specific temple ritual under stress, linking him to the old murder file.
- **Arc:** From a strict enforcer of the law to someone who looks the other way, allowing the Goddess's justice to be completed.

Deba (45) — No relation - the wealthy local contractor

Henchman / Victim. Loud printed shirts, heavy gold chains, constantly chewing paan.

- **Wants:** To secure the temple demolition contract from Balaram.
- **Needs:** To confess his sins before the Goddess.
- **Secret:** He kept a silver coin from the temple treasury as a twisted lucky charm.
- **Lie they believe:** Believes his wealth has washed away the sins of his past.
- **Changes the plot when:** He dies in the cold open, screaming from phantom burns, setting the entire investigation in motion.

- **Arc:** Dies early, establishing the terrifying stakes and the method of the Goddess's vengeance.

Sulochana (75) — His father's mother (deceased)

Mentor (Posthumous). Seen in flashbacks and photos: traditional white widow's saree, deep wrinkles, fearful eyes.

- **Wants:** To protect Soumya from the village's curse.
- **Needs:** To tell the truth about her son's murder.
- **Secret:** She recognized Deba and Balaram in the mob but stayed silent to keep Soumya alive.
- **Lie they believe:** Believed running away would permanently sever their ties to Kali Mata.
- **Changes the plot when:** Leaves behind audio cassettes disguising the perpetrators' identities as demons in Danda Nata fables, giving clues to the hidden box.
- **Arc:** Remains a tragic figure, but her voice from the past guides Soumya to the truth.

Madhab (25) — No relation - local temple caretaker

False Suspect. Ash smeared on forehead, wears simple dhoti, gaunt and intense.

- **Wants:** To restore the Kali temple to its former glory.
- **Needs:** To find a true purpose beyond blind fanaticism.
- **Secret:** He has been sneaking into the clinic at night to steal medical supplies for the village poor.
- **Lie they believe:** Believes the Goddess requires human blood sacrifice from the villagers to be appeased.
- **Changes the plot when:** He is caught washing a blood-soaked shirt near the temple, making him the prime suspect for the supernatural murders.
- **Arc:** From a creepy, suspicious fanatic to a loyal devotee who realizes the true avatar is Soumya.

The villain's plan: Balaram Rout plans to secure his upcoming re-election by initiating a massive commercial development over the sacred temple lands, turning Rambhadipur into a lucrative tourist hub. He forces the local PWD Executive Engineer to issue a fraudulent 'structurally unsafe' certificate to legally bulldoze the eyeless Kali temple. When the bizarre murders of his old co-conspirators begin, he assumes it is political sabotage or a surviving relative. His plan is to identify the killer and frame them, inciting a village mob to enact instant justice exactly as he did to the Pujari 15 years ago. He is completely convinced he is right, believing that progress, wealth, and power justify erasing obsolete, superstitious traditions and anyone who clings to them.

4. Facts sheet

Jobs and money:

- Dr. Soumya earns a lucrative salary at a private city hospital but carries a heavy mortgage, leaving him with little liquid cash.
- Balaram Rout possesses massive untraceable cash reserves hidden in agricultural fronts, allowing him to buy off local authorities.
- Rambhadipur's economy is entirely dependent on Balaram's construction jobs and seasonal farming, making the villagers fearful of crossing him.
- IIC Meera operates out of an underfunded rural Rambhadipur Police Station, lacking the forensic resources of city police.

Health:

- Soumya suffers from severe repressed trauma that manifests as what he thinks is extreme exhaustion, but is actually an unknown parasomnia state where his mind is suppressed.
- The victims die from bizarre trauma mimicking Danda Nata penances, but are actually executed via Soumya's terrifying medical precision (e.g., corrosive clinical chemicals to simulate internal fire, or severed vocal cord nerves causing dry drowning).
- Sulochana died of a sudden, severe stroke, which acted as the psychological trigger for Soumya's repressed memories.
- Due to his medical training, Soumya has high physical stamina and anatomical knowledge, which the Goddess utilizes to enact precise, lethal justice.

Belongings and vehicles:

- Soumya drives a mid-range, heavily financed SUV that stands out awkwardly in the dusty village streets.
- Balaram travels in a convoy of matching white Scorpios, symbolizing his political dominance and intimidation.
- Kavita carries a sealed pre-filled syringe (PFS) of Midazolam, a highly restricted city medical supply.
- Balaram wields a prominent silver-headed walking stick that he uses aggressively to point and intimidate the villagers.

Places:

- Rambhadipur is a sweltering, drought-prone village characterized by red dust, intense heat, and narrow, claustrophobic lanes.
- The old Kali temple is half-ruined, overgrown with banyan roots, and houses a terrifying, eyeless idol of the Goddess shrouded in darkness.
- The village clinic is a dusty, poorly lit two-room concrete structure with flickering tube lights and a rusty examination table.
- Soumya's apartment in Bhubaneswar is sleek, sterile, and heavily air-conditioned, representing the safe, modern world he is forced to abandon.

Rules of this world:

- The Goddess cannot manifest as a ghost or floating spirit; she strictly requires a traumatized human blood-vessel from the Pujari's lineage to affect the physical world.
- The possession can only occur when the vessel's conscious mind is completely suppressed, which happens during Soumya's deep sleeping states.
- Supernatural vengeance adheres strictly to the rules of karma and the specific rituals of the Danda Nata (Dhuli Danda for greed, Pani Danda for deceit).
- Technology functions normally in this world; the supernatural does not disable cameras or phones, which is why Soumya's physical actions are ultimately captured on CCTV.
- In Odisha, ancient temples fall strictly under the Hindu Religious Endowments Act, meaning demolition requires manipulating high-level district administration like a PWD Executive Engineer and Tahasildar, not just a village Panchayat.

5. The climax (designed first)

Where/when: The final night of the Chaitra month festival during the Meru Jatra, directly in front of the half-ruined Kali temple in Rambhadipur, surrounded by a violent village mob.

The reversal: Balaram successfully incites the mob to execute Soumya, perfectly mirroring the Pujari's murder 15 years ago. Instead of trying to escape, Soumya realizes the only way to expose Balaram and save the village is to stop fighting his exhaustion and let history repeat itself with a divine twist.

The hero's choice: Cornered before being dragged out, Soumya secretly injects himself with Kavita's Pre-Filled Syringe (PFS) of Midazolam. He stalls the mob with a speech while waiting for the drug to cross his blood-brain barrier, intentionally inducing the deep-sleep state required for the Goddess to possess him completely.

The cost: He permanently breaks his medical oath, becomes a wanted fugitive on the run, loses his modern life and fiancée, and accepts his fate as the eternal, unwilling vessel of Kali Mata.

Payoffs that fire:

- Kavita's Pre-Filled Syringe (PFS) of Midazolam.
- Sulochana's cassette tape fable about the Demon King's silver leg.
- The Danda Nata Jhuna (flammable resin) throwing ritual.

Final image: Soumya, now a fugitive, walking alone on a dark Odia highway at dawn. As he passes under a flickering streetlight, his shadow momentarily projects multiple arms holding a blade, before returning to the silhouette of a solitary man.

Why "wow": The audience realizes the hero's ultimate victory requires him to actively surrender his free will to the Goddess, weaponizing modern psychiatry to enact ancient divine justice right in front of the villain who thought he had won.

After: Balaram is dead and his 15-year corruption is exposed. IIC Meera closes the old murder file but must now hunt Soumya. Kavita returns to the city heartbroken, knowing her medicine doomed him. The village's Kali idol finally has its diamond eyes restored by the blood-soaked hands of the Pujari's son.

6. Setups and payoffs

Setup	Planted	Payoff	Paid off
A battery-operated CCTV camera Soumya installs in the clinic, but his laptop charger breaks so he cannot view the SD card footage.	Episode 3, when Soumya wakes up to find muddy footprints leading in and out of his clinic window.	Soumya and Kavita finally use her city laptop and adapters to check the footage, watching in horror as Soumya's sleeping body takes a surgical scalpel and walks into the night.	Episode 6.
Sulochana's audio cassette tells a Danda Nata fable about the 'Demon of the Red Dirt' who swallowed two stars and hid them in his silver leg.	Episode 2, while Soumya is driving his SUV through the dusty village lanes.	Possessed Soumya breaks open Balaram's signature silver-headed walking stick to reveal the original stolen diamond eyes of the Kali idol.	Episode 8 (Climax).
Kavita brings a powerful Pre-Filled Syringe (PFS) of Midazolam, begging	Episode 5, during a heated argument about medical	Cornered by the mob, Soumya secretly injects himself with the Midazolam syringe	Episode 8 (Climax).

Setup	Planted	Payoff	Paid off
Soumya to use it so he can be safely taken to a city hospital.	ethics and his declining safety.	to force the deep-sleep state, stalling with a speech until Kali takes over to fight back.	
A heavy metal chisel his father used for temple maintenance, mentioned in Sulochana's cassettes.	Episode 4, when Soumya searches for physical proof of his family's past.	Soumya uses the heavy metal chisel to pry up a hidden loose stone beneath the Kali idol's altar to uncover Deba's 2009 ledger.	Episode 7.

7. Episode blueprints

Episode 1: The Eyeless Mother

- **Cold open:** The sweltering heat of Chaitra month. Soumya wakes up on the morning of the festival with a strange blister on his hand and the faint smell of Jhuna resin. Later, during the Danda Nata fire penance, local contractor Deba suddenly screams in agony. His skin blisters from the inside out, and he collapses dead beneath the terrifying, eyeless Kali idol.
- **Question:** What invisible force is causing a grotesque, fiery epidemic in the village of Rambhadipur?
- **Hero's move:** Soumya is forced to pronounce Deba dead at the scene. He secretly extracts a blackened, ancient silver coin from the victim's throat with forceps just seconds before Balaram's men forcefully confiscate the body.
- **Villain's move:** MLA Balaram Rout immediately orders his men to seize Deba's body and cremate it without a police report, desperate to destroy any evidence connecting the death to the temple.
- **Clue (earned):** Soumya takes the mysterious coin to the fanatic temple caretaker, Madhab, who identifies the marking as a specific token from the old temple treasury, establishing their dynamic.
- **False lead:** The village headman claims Deba contracted a rare, highly contagious skin virus from the city.
- **Hero learns:** The physical trauma on the victim was a chemically induced internal burn (from a corrosive clinical chemical slipped into him), which the villagers mistake for supernatural fire.
- **Audience learns:** Balaram is terrified of something from his past, and Soumya is deeply connected to this temple.
- **Set piece:** The chaotic, hypnotic Danda Nata Agni Danda (fire penance) ritual, filled with drums, trance, and sudden, inexplicable death.
- **Side story:** IIC Meera arrives from the Rambhadipur Police Station, instantly suspicious of Balaram's rushed cremation orders.
- **Turn:** Soumya decides to stay in Rambhadipur, using his own money to keep the clinic open to medically investigate the 'disease' himself.
- **Ending hook:** Soumya realizes the internal chemical burn on Deba mirrors the exact size of the strange, unexplained blister he woke up with on his own hand that morning.
- **Plants:** Danda Nata performers throwing Jhuna (flammable tree resin) into fire, creating massive, intense bursts of flame.; Soumya's unexplained blister and the smell of Jhuna resin on his fingers.

Episode 2: Demon of the Red Dirt

- **Cold open:** Soumya drives his heavily financed SUV through the claustrophobic, red-dust lanes of Rambhadipur, listening to his late grandmother's cassette tapes. He blows a tire right outside the overgrown ruins of the Kali temple.
- **Question:** Can Soumya trace an environmental toxin before the village's corruption buries the evidence?

- **Hero's move:** Acting as a pragmatist, Soumya investigates a local surveyor to trace an environmental toxin in the red dirt to explain the 'disease', actively tracking down the man's recent work sites.
- **Villain's move:** Balaram pressures the local PWD Executive Engineer to issue a fraudulent 'structurally unsafe' certificate and the Tahasildar to illegally transfer the title, giving him the pretext to bulldoze the temple rapidly.
- **Clue (earned):** Soumya breaks into the surveyor's locked field office and finds a hidden ledger detailing illegal temple land transfers.
- **False lead:** The surveyor's death looks like an asthma attack brought on by a sudden dust storm.
- **Hero learns:** The surveyor and Deba were both part of a specific land-grab operation fifteen years ago.
- **Audience learns:** The 'Demon' in Sulochana's fairy tale is actually Balaram Rout.
- **Set piece:** The Dhuli Danda (Dust Penance) sequence: The corrupt surveyor is trapped in his own vehicle and suffocates. Medical inspection later shows a clinical intubation tube was forcefully used to pack temple dust down his windpipe.
- **Side story:** Balaram walks with a prominent silver-headed walking stick, aggressively using it to point and intimidate the villagers.
- **Turn:** IIC Meera confiscates the ledger from Soumya, warning him not to play detective and interfering in police work.
- **Ending hook:** Soumya runs tox screens and realizes the surveyor's lungs are caked in the exact same ancient red dust found only inside the sealed inner sanctum of the Kali temple.
- **Plants:** Sulochana's audio cassette tells a Danda Nata fable about the 'Demon of the Red Dirt' who swallowed two stars and hid them in his silver leg.

Episode 3: The Midnight Scalpel

- **Cold open:** Soumya wakes up on his clinic cot, inexplicably exhausted and aching. He checks his medical kit and finds a surgical scalpel and bandages missing, with muddy footprints leading from the clinic window to the medical cabinet and back out the window.
- **Question:** Who is breaking into the clinic at night and stealing medical supplies?
- **Hero's move:** Refusing to involve the corrupt local police, Soumya purchases and secretly installs a battery-operated CCTV camera above the clinic window to catch the intruder.
- **Villain's move:** Balaram feeds IIC Meera a fabricated tip that the temple caretaker, Madhab, has a violent grudge against the dead men.
- **Clue (earned):** Soumya finds a scrap of a traditional Odia dhoti snagged on the clinic's rear window frame, matching Madhab's clothing.
- **False lead:** Madhab, the temple caretaker, is seen sneaking around the clinic in the dead of night with a suspicious bag.
- **Hero learns:** Someone with physical access to his clinic is directly involved in the bizarre village events.
- **Audience learns:** Soumya's extreme exhaustion is worsening; he is losing chunks of time entirely, and his laptop charger breaks, preventing him from checking the CCTV SD card.
- **Set piece:** A tense, silent nighttime stakeout inside the pitch-black clinic, as Soumya waits with a flashlight for the thief to arrive.
- **Side story:** Madhab is secretly stealing expired painkillers to treat poor villagers who Balaram has banned from the hospital.
- **Turn:** IIC Meera arrests Madhab based on Balaram's tip, closing the official investigation.
- **Ending hook:** Soumya secretly follows Madhab into the temple ruins and watches in shock as the caretaker carefully washes a freshly blood-soaked shirt, burying it under the Banyan roots.

- **Plants:** A battery-operated CCTV camera Soumya installs in the clinic, but his laptop charger breaks so he cannot view the SD card footage.

Episode 4: The Water Penance

- **Cold open:** Flashback to April 2009: A young Soumya cowers under a bed as violent mob noises echo outside. His grandmother Sulochana frantically packs a single bag, her hands covered in someone else's blood.
- **Question:** What is the true connection between Soumya's family and the targeted men?
- **Hero's move:** Using a heavy metal chisel his father used for temple maintenance and a specific clue from his grandmother's tapes, Soumya pries up a hidden loose stone beneath the Kali idol's altar to uncover physical proof.
- **Villain's move:** Balaram hires outside thugs in white Scorpios to patrol the village, enforcing a strict curfew to protect his remaining allies.
- **Clue (earned):** Under the altar, Soumya discovers a 15-year-old bloodstained cloth wrapped around an empty jewelry box—hastily stashed by his father during a violent struggle.
- **False lead:** The local drunk claims he saw a vengeful ghost drowning people in the pond.
- **Hero learns:** The Kali idol did not just lose its eyes to decay; they were violently pried out, and his father bled trying to protect the empty box.
- **Audience learns:** IIC Meera watches Soumya subconsciously perform a highly specific, obscure finger-folding ritual (mudra) while stressed, matching it to notes and photos from the 15-year-old Pujari murder file, deducing he is the victim's son.
- **Set piece:** The Pani Danda (Water Penance): Balaram's former corrupt police chief is found standing frozen in the waist-deep village pond, dead. Autopsy reveals he drowned with dry lungs due to surgically severed vocal cord nerves.
- **Side story:** Meera connects the names of the current victims directly to the mob that murdered the Pujari 15 years ago.
- **Turn:** Meera confronts Soumya at the clinic, revealing his true identity and accusing him of returning for revenge.
- **Ending hook:** Balaram, informed by a spy that the Pujari's son has returned, smiles coldly and says, 'Time to finish what we started.'
- **Plants:** A heavy metal chisel his father used for temple maintenance, mentioned in Sulochana's cassettes.

Episode 5: The Sedative

- **Cold open:** Kavita, Soumya's fiancée and medical colleague, arrives in Rambhadiapur in a sleek city car with mobile lab equipment, determined to help him cure the 'epidemic'. She is horrified to find him looking manic and hollow-eyed.
- **Question:** Can Soumya's modern medical logic explain away his deteriorating mental state?
- **Hero's move:** Desperate for answers about the bloody shirt, Soumya sneaks into the local lockup by bribing a guard, forcing a face-to-face confrontation with the imprisoned Madhab.
- **Villain's move:** Balaram uses his political influence to have the District Medical Officer abruptly revoke Soumya's license and seal the clinic under false 'biohazard' pretenses, crippling him legally and physically.
- **Clue (earned):** Madhab reveals to Soumya that the bloody shirt wasn't his; he found it draped over the Kali idol and hid it to protect the Goddess's true avatar.
- **False lead:** Kavita insists Soumya's symptoms are just extreme stress-induced psychosis from being back in a traumatizing place.

- **Hero learns:** Madhab is innocent, and whoever is committing the murders is trying to frame Soumya or is intrinsically tied to him.
- **Audience learns:** Kavita secretly brought psychiatric tools to Rambhadipur, struggling with her medical ethics as she realizes Soumya might be a danger.
- **Set piece:** A chaotic clash at the clinic when Balaram's men arrive to seal it. Soumya uses his anatomical knowledge to brutally incapacitate a thug, showcasing a disturbing physical capability.
- **Side story:** Kavita desperately analyzes the tox screens, realizing that medical science is completely failing to explain the village deaths.
- **Turn:** Soumya refuses to leave with Kavita, realizing that running away 15 years ago is what allowed Balaram to destroy his family.
- **Ending hook:** During a heated argument, Kavita pulls out a sealed Pre-Filled Syringe (PFS) of Midazolam, begging him to use it. Soumya refuses, but asks for her laptop adapter so they can finally check the CCTV SD card from days ago.
- **Plants:** Kavita brings a powerful Pre-Filled Syringe (PFS) of Midazolam, begging Soumya to use it so he can be safely taken to a city hospital.

Episode 6: The Footage

- **Cold open:** IIC Meera examines the corpse of the drowned police chief on a slab. She discovers precise, surgical incisions behind the victim's ears—cuts that only a highly trained doctor could make in the dark.
- **Question:** Who is the invisible assassin executing the Danda Nata penances?
- **Hero's move:** Using Kavita's modern laptop and adapters, Soumya finally removes the SD card from the battery-operated CCTV and plays it to identify the killer.
- **Villain's move:** Balaram publicly announces a massive bounty on the killer's head, officially naming 'the deranged city doctor' as the prime suspect to whip the village into a frenzy.
- **Clue (earned):** The video timestamp matches the exact hour of the police chief's drowning (from Episode 4).
- **False lead:** None. The brutal truth is revealed.
- **Hero learns:** Soumya watches the footage in absolute horror: his own sleeping body climbs out the window, eyes wide but unseeing, grabs a surgical scalpel, and walks out into the night with lethal purpose.
- **Audience learns:** Soumya is the killer. The Goddess is using his suppressed trauma to commandeer his body and enact divine retribution using terrifying medical precision.
- **Set piece:** A tense, psychological sequence of Soumya and Kavita watching his terrifying, fluid movements on screen, intercut with flashes of the actual physical murders he committed while unconscious.
- **Side story:** Meera officially issues a warrant for Soumya's arrest based on the surgical evidence.
- **Turn:** Accepting his horrific guilt, Soumya packs his bags to surrender to Meera and protect the village from himself, while Kavita agonizingly decides to leave the Midazolam syringe with him.
- **Ending hook:** Soumya tries to drive out of Rambhadipur, but a convoy of Balaram's white Scorpios blocks the only highway out, trapping him in the village.
- **Pays off:** Soumya and Kavita finally use her city laptop and adapters to check the footage, watching in horror as Soumya's sleeping body takes a surgical scalpel and walks into the night.

Episode 7: History Repeats

- **Cold open:** Nightfall. Balaram stands on the hood of his Scorpio with a loudspeaker, rallying a mob with torches. He declares Soumya a demon cursing the village—a direct, chilling mirror of the night the Pujari was killed.

- **Question:** Can Soumya survive the mob justice that claimed his father?
- **Hero's move:** Trapped and hunted, Soumya deliberately retreats to the overgrown ruins of the Kali temple, realizing it's the only place he can find the final clue before he dies.
- **Villain's move:** Balaram uses local trackers and hunting dogs to orchestrate a ruthless manhunt, cornering Soumya naturally while whipping the mob into a frenzy with false documents planted at the sealed clinic.
- **Clue (earned):** Using the heavy chisel, Soumya pries deeper into the temple stones and finds the contractor Deba's original 2009 ledger hidden in the idol's base, proving Balaram and Deba were physically inside the sanctum on the night of the theft.
- **False lead:** Meera believes Balaram is just trying to protect the village, unaware he orchestrated the original theft.
- **Hero learns:** Balaram didn't just frame his father; he is using the exact same tactic to eliminate Soumya and bulldoze the temple for a resort.
- **Audience learns:** The Goddess has cornered Soumya deliberately, forcing him to make a stand exactly where his father fell.
- **Set piece:** A high-stakes, claustrophobic game of cat-and-mouse through the festival-decorated village alleys, with the sounds of the Meru Jatra drums and hunting dogs masking the mob's approach.
- **Side story:** Kavita and Meera cross paths, realizing that Balaram's mob is about to commit a murder, forcing Meera to finally turn against the MLA.
- **Turn:** Soumya realizes he cannot outrun the mob or legally expose a man as powerful as Balaram. The system is rigged.
- **Ending hook:** The heavy wooden doors of the temple are smashed open. The mob drags a bloodied Soumya out into the festival square as the Meru Jatra drums reach a deafening crescendo.
- **Pays off:** Soumya uses the heavy metal chisel to pry up a hidden loose stone beneath the Kali idol's altar to uncover Deba's 2009 ledger.

Episode 8: Meru Jatra

- **Cold open:** The final night of Chaitra. Torches blaze in the festival square. Balaram stands victorious before the eyeless Kali idol, watching his men beat Soumya to his knees. History is perfectly repeating itself.
- **Question:** Will Soumya surrender to the mob, or surrender to the Goddess to break the cycle?
- **Hero's move:** Realizing logic and law have failed, Soumya stops fighting. Cornered before being dragged out, he secretly injected himself with Kavita's PFS of Midazolam. He stalls the mob with a speech, voluntarily waiting for the drug to cross his blood-brain barrier to induce the deep-sleep state.
- **Villain's move:** Balaram steps forward to deliver the killing blow with his silver-headed walking stick, screaming that tradition is dead.
- **Clue (earned):** As Balaram swings, the drug hits. Soumya's eyes roll back, and possessed, he catches the walking stick mid-air and snaps it in half.
- **False lead:** The mob thinks Soumya is passing out from fear, dropping their guard.
- **Hero learns:** The ultimate truth of his grandmother's fable: Balaram kept the Goddess's eyes hidden in plain sight inside the walking stick.
- **Audience learns:** Soumya accepts the immense cost of vengeance, permanently sacrificing his humanity and modern life to become Kali's vessel.
- **Set piece:** The ultimate Agni Danda. A terrifying, supernatural martial sequence where the unconscious, possessed Soumya moves with divine brutality, using crushed Jhuna dust and clinic alcohol to overpower and ignite Balaram.

- **Side story:** Kavita and Meera arrive just in time to watch Soumya exact impossible, ritualistic justice, realizing the supernatural is horrifyingly real.
- **Turn:** Possessed Soumya retrieves the original stolen diamond eyes from the broken silver walking stick and restores them to the Kali idol.
- **Ending hook:** Wanted for murder and stripped of his old life, Soumya walks away. Final image: A fugitive walking alone on a dark Odia highway at dawn. As he passes under a flickering streetlight, his shadow momentarily projects multiple arms holding a blade, before returning to the silhouette of a solitary man.
- **Pays off:** Cornered by the mob, Soumya secretly injects himself with the Midazolam syringe to force the deep-sleep state, stalling with a speech until Kali takes over to fight back.; Possessed Soumya breaks open Balaram's signature silver-headed walking stick to reveal the original stolen diamond eyes of the Kali idol.

Appendix: the pitch room

Direction 1: Bishpan: Eyes of the Mother — A rationalist investigative journalist from Bhubaneswar returns to his disgraced ancestral village to solve a series of bizarre murders linked to a stolen goddess, unaware that he himself is the divine weapon of vengeance. Scores — hook 7, freshness 6, climax 7, faithful 10. Hits all prompt requirements including the grandmother, but relies heavily on the clichéd mirror reveal and generic investigative thriller tropes.

Direction 2 (chosen): Bishpan: The Dust Penance — When a mysterious madness strikes the village that exiled his family, a pragmatic doctor returns to cure the afflicted, only to discover the disease is a bloody retribution acting through his own hands. Scores — hook 9, freshness 9, climax 9, faithful 10. Deeply rooted in authentic Odisha culture with Danda Nata acting as the murder blueprint, and the medical protagonist makes the supernatural twist hit much harder.

Direction 3: Bishpan: The Silent Tandav — An ambitious structural engineer returns to Rambhadipur to survey an ancient ruined temple for a resort project, accidentally triggering a violent supernatural purge of the men who murdered his father. Scores — hook 7, freshness 6, climax 8, faithful 10. Clever use of modern security footage to reveal the twist, but suffers from cultural inaccuracy by mixing Vaishnav traditions like Mahari and Ashtaprahari with Tantric Kali worship.

Why the critic chose it: It integrates Odisha's culture perfectly by using the physical penance rituals of Danda Nata as the exact method of the murders, fulfilling the 'Culture as Engine' rule. A doctor protagonist provides a strong, rational counterpoint that makes his eventual possession terrifying rather than expected.

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